



Defending champion and World No. 1 Novak Djokovic capitalised, prevailing in a Grand Slam record 5-hour and 53-minute final. "I think we played a great tennis match. It was a very good show," said Nadal, who had lost to the Serb for the seventh consecutive time. Djokovic called the epic "definitely the greatest match I've ever played."

🎾 **Nadal def. Djokovic 6-4, 3-6, 6-1, 6-7(3), 9-7 — 2013 French Open semifinal**

The stakes could not have been higher: Nadal was aiming for a record eighth title at Roland Garros, while

Djokovic sought the only Grand Slam that had eluded him. He was also bidding to become the first man since Rod Laver in 1969 to complete a calendar Grand Slam. In what was considered the de facto final, Nadal clawed back from a 4-2 deficit in the deciding set to secure a thrilling victory in four hours and 37 minutes.

McEnroe summed it up for *NBC* when he said: "It's nice when something lives up to what you built it up to, and this 'match of the year' was all you could ask for.... You can make an argument that the match was the greatest we've ever witnessed on a

Inflection point: Tennis got a new king in 2008 after Nadal dashed Federer's hopes of winning his sixth Wimbledon crown in a pulsating final.

clay court."

A powerful argument indeed!

Evolution of a legend

I first saw this whiz kid play around 2003 on my old-fashioned 28-inch TV. His performance left me gobsmacked as Nadal sprinted so far to retrieve shots that he briefly disappeared from the screen, only to reappear and stay in the point after three, four, or

- In 2010, Nadal became the only player to win all three clay-court Masters 1000 tournaments — Monte Carlo, Madrid, and Rome — as well as the French Open in the same season, achieving a historic sweep of the four most prestigious annual clay events.

- Helped his country win five editions of the Davis Cup — 2004, 2008, 2009, 2011 and 2019 — tying McEnroe for the Open Era record.

- His 112-4 match record at Roland Garros also gave him the highest winning percentage — 96.5 per cent — of any singles player at any Major.